

ActInf GuestStream 069.1 ~ Andrew McLuhan: "Marshall McLuhan and Project 69"

GuestStream | Andrew McLuhan | 1:19:33

Hello and welcome everyone. This is Active Inference Guest Stream 69.1 on February 6th, 2024. Really looking forward to this session and conversation with Andrew McLuhan. We will be hearing about Marshall McLuhan and Project 69. So it's an incredibly auspicious numerological coincidence and I look forward to hearing about what you're going to share right now, Andrew. So thank you very much. To you. Thank you. Yeah, well, I noticed that the stream was 69.1 or whatever. So I thought, well, I guess I know what I'm going to talk about. You know, actually, numbers, numerology is important in McLuhan work. Maybe not in the full blown mystical sense of it, although that too sometimes. But the number 69 comes up a few times in a very vanilla kind of way. Um, well, Marshall loved the number three for a few reasons. Uh, the Trivium was a pet subject of his grammar, rhetoric, dialectic. Uh, there was his PhD work, uh, on the Trivium, for example. Um, also the Holy Trinity, you know, Father, Son, Holy Spirit. Um, and the McLuhans lived in Toronto for the longest time at number three, which would park, which seemed auspicious to them, I'm sure. Um, you know, 69. Three is, is a route of 69, of course. Um, Marshall McLuhan was 69 years old when he died. Uh, amazingly enough, he wasn't, uh, that old according, you know, people tend to live longer than that. I often wonder if he'd lived five more years, you know, even five more years, where would his work have taken him? What direction? Um, I think about this a lot when people, when people say, well, what would Marshall McLuhan say about this? Or if Marshall McLuhan was here today, what would he say? And even on, on my own, when I, when I'm, you know, when I have a topic, I'm, I'm thinking about researching or writing, I ask myself, you know, what would Marshall say about this? And the answer is, we have no way of knowing because he only died at the age. He wasn't 70 years old when he died. He could have had a lot more, um, time to develop his work. Uh, at the time of his death, he'd already developed his work a lot further than what most people know about, you know, his whole work with the laws of media with my father. If he'd had another five or 10 years, how much further would he develop that work? And what would he say about today? With that in mind, you know, if he had lived another decade, he would have actually seen the early internet. He died in 1980. Um, I think about these things, but, you know, number 69, uh, brings to mind to me, uh, project 69, which, uh, was a grant awarded by the NAEB, the National Association of Educational Broadcasters from Washington, DC, to Marshall McLuhan in order to, uh, undergo a study in understanding new media. Um, this was in 1958. Marshall received this, uh, important grant, foundational grant for him. Um, the first major grant he received with his friend, Ted Carpenter was in the early 1950s, um, from the Ford Foundation. And that started off, uh, a culture and communication seminar they undertook, which was an early interdisciplinary study of communication, which turned into for, for Marshall and others, the birth of media studies, not simply communication studies, the enlarging of this category from simple communication to media, to all human innovation and its effects. Um, the, the second very important grant was this NAEB grant, which, um, gave Marshall the resources, uh, to undergo serious study

of technology and media. And the results of his studies for the next two years, 58 to 60, um, would really underpin and inform the rest of his, his work for the next, uh, two decades almost. This is when Marshall came up with this formulation, the medium is the message, among, among other things. Um, it's when, when Marshall, uh, received this grant, which was for essentially to create a high school curriculum for understanding media. Um, Marshall set about, uh, doing that and he delivered it in, in what's called the report on the project and understanding new media, which he delivered to the NAEB in 1960. Um, this report didn't really go anywhere, uh, within the NAEB. It didn't become the United States or Canada's high school curriculum for understanding media, although it would be amazing if it had, uh, it kind of fell flat. Um, I think, you know, like, like a lot of McClone's work, people didn't know what to do with it, right? Uh, laws of media, which maybe we'll talk about as well, um, was an outgrowth of this whole process. And again, people didn't know what to do with. In fact, nobody would publish it up until my father managed to convince somebody in 1988, eight years after Marshall died. But, um, what Marshall did was he took this report and he spent the next four years, 1960 to 1964, um, revising it, chopping it down, taking it apart, putting it back together, rewriting and rewriting, um, basically condensing it down into poetry. And it was published in 1964 as Understanding Media, The Extensions of Man. So this was Marshall taking, um, and it's fascinating to look at the report that he delivered in 1960, because stylistically it's so much different. You would almost think it's completely different material. Um, but it's not, it's the, the book through McGraw Hill is basically, um, just another version, you know, as if you were to make a film from a book, this is making a book from a report, in many senses. Um, and so in making, in making a, a popular book from the report, uh, he did some interesting things for one thing. There's, there's a narrative structure, um, at work in, in the book Understanding Media. Um, it opens up with, you know, after 3000 years of print dominance, essentially, um, you know, it's a shock to find it that the medium is the message. The book is essentially, um, um, rests on top of the story of the change between eras from the, uh, the alphabet mechanistic era to the electric era, which were currently, uh, still riding out. I, I, I feel like to me, I put it like this, you know, if, if the alphabet, the ultimate extension of the alphabet was the technique of fragmentation, you know, coming to a peak with the industrial age in the late 19th, early 20th century, um, you know, perhaps right now we are at a similar extension of the technique of electricity with digitization and AI. It feels like a, like an apt comparison. Um, and it would be, it would be interesting to, to rewrite this narrative, uh, rewrite this book of tools and information on the top of that narrative rather than the switch from mechanistic to electrical, but from electrical, electrical to digitized to AI, which I think is more of a transition, uh, in outgrowth than, than a straight up flip of errors. But, um, you know, the one, the one enduring, uh, interest of Marshall was in, um, as he said, understanding the processes, uh, in which we are involved. He was, um, this is, this was his preoccupation with, with media and structure and form over content, uh, meaning, uh, which again is an interesting tension and paradox because he was an English teacher and he was very, very interested in content. Um, he, he loved content, you know, he left poetry.

That was his, his thing, poetry and literature, his specialty. Um, media studies was his, was a side hustle that he kind of fell into and kind of overtook everything else. But his interests, uh, in both subjects were the same. He was interested in structure and effect. Um, that was his interest in poetry and literature, which grew out of his work at Cambridge university, studying under, um, people like, uh, Leavis, FR Leavis and IA Richards who founded practical criticism. Um, you know, McLuhan work is essentially, uh, practical criticism applied to technology and culture over simply literature and poetry. Um, um, so this was, was McLuhan's enduring interest structure and effect, um, the effective structure and form rather than simply, uh, meaning and effective content. Um, you know, that's more toward media literacy and propaganda, uh, studies, which again are important, but they're, um, and they're related, obviously, but they're separate categories. Uh, and, uh, you know, our, our interests tend to be more toward, uh, structure and form rather than content, uh, which isn't to say again, that content is, is meaningless or ineffective because obviously it is, but, um, you know, the main point of understanding media is that the, the main effects in reshaping people individually and people culturally and societally comes less from the content or uses to which technologies are put and more from the structure of the technologies itself as they reshape us and reshape our environment, which then reshape us again and again. So, um, so that's my, my opening gambit, I guess.

Awesome. What, what a gambit.

For those who are watching live, let's grab some questions, use a live stream, media, mediatic affordance. There's just many places to, um, jump in. Where, where would you like to start? Well, for one thing, I want to know what's happening with the, the, the pyramid triangle set up behind you there.

Good question. I use a lot of tetrahedra to symbolize Bucky Fuller's synergetics and the different first principle, the different starting point in synergetics, as opposed to kind of the water we swim in today is rather than starting with a three-dimensional X, Y, Z cube, starting with a tetrahedron, four events, the minimum enclosed system kind of comes up again in active inference with the four-fold particular partition. And so it just reminds me that space is not necessarily cubic and that even our space and time projection is heavily in feedback with the angles that we see. So I look forward, I see a 90 degree angle and I can imagine space is cubic, but then I can look back and see that it doesn't have to be that way. Okay. Can you, can you back up a second and talk a little bit more about active inference in the four-fold what now? Yes. So to the four-foldness of active inference, one of the key developments of active inference, though it's in the tradition of cybernetics and ecological psychology is heavily resting upon a particular partition. And so it's a little bit of a pun because it's that specific particular way to partition agents from the environment. And then also what it individuates is called the particle. And so the first cleaving is the environment from the agent. So the external states from the particle, and then the particle itself, there's a three-foldness, which is the incoming sensory information, the internal cognitive states, and then the outgoing action dependencies. And so the incoming sensory states and the outgoing action states that defines like the blanket or the interface. So the particle sometimes is described as the interface plus the internals,

or to zoom in on the blanket or the interface, there's the incoming aspect of the interface, the sense, and then there's the outgoing dependencies on the blanket, which is the action. And then everything that happens behind the back black box, that's the cognitive internal states.

David Plylar

Okay. That's interesting. It's not unrelated to something I've been working on for quite a while, which is a McLuhan model of communication or of media, which does not exist, really. When you look up models of communication, McLuhan isn't in the conversation, which is interesting. And I felt that was a significant gap. And that's led me to, I've been toying with this for a year or so anyway, you know, put against, for example, the Shannon Weaver model of communication, where you have, you know, the source and then the message to be shipped somewhere and then received. The McLuhan model is a bit deeper than that, you know, Marshall says that Shannon Weaver is a model of transportation, you know, moving information from one place to another. And his is a model of transformation, or what happens along the way. And at the end, you know, how we are changed, again, effect, right. So how, you know, I stare, I've got it over there on a board, and I look at this Weaver model and think how to include, uh, McLuhan's ideas, notions about technology and its effects into a model, a trend. What does a transformation model look like graphically? And it's, it's some, it's a little bit related to what you were talking about with particular partition. But the main, the main area of focus is, is on the senses. So the impact of information or data or stimulus, stimuli on our senses, because uh, the way you hear people talk about it, it's as if the, these senses are, are static things and they're not, uh, or they're passive things and they're not. Um, the, you know, the data, the information is, is color is received, uh, but the way it's received is, has everything to do with the nature of the senses receiving it.

And, uh, the senses don't simply, it's not like a straw, right, that you suck liquid through, um, because, uh, you know, it's, it's very much transformed and we are transformed reciprocally, right? There's, there's a reciprocal thing that happens. Um, the other thing, uh, which needs to be taken into account is that when we talk about the senses, when we think about the senses, um, we need to think about them individually, but we also need to think about them collectively. Because our, our senses, our bodily senses, our interior senses, um, they all exist in a balance, in a ratio among themselves. You know, we speak of the sensorium as one thing. And that again is, not a static thing. It's a dynamic thing. Uh, to change, to affect one sense is to affect all the senses, uh, by either numbing them or activating. And when you alter a sense, um, you alter all the other senses because you alter the relationship among them. If you, if you go, if you, well, if you even close your eyes, uh, you know, when you're trying to hear something, uh, really closely, you close your eyes and kind of point your ear toward it, right? Because you want to cut off the visual faculty, which is dominating things. And you want to focus all your energy toward that sense. Um, when people go blind, uh, they almost universally talk about how their other senses perk up. Um, that's because your senses react and they pick up the slack and they change you, uh, fundamentally,

you know, mechanically as to who you are, but also, um, how you identify, you know, how you see yourselves,

how others see you, right? For example, if I were a blind person, your background there would have no significance for me, uh, or for you, right? Like you would probably be sitting in front of blank walls, maybe white, maybe not, who knows, who cares, right? They have zero meaning. Uh, but that little assembly behind you is a reflection and, and of impactful and necessary reflection of your identity. Um, you know, I went through a house fire when I was a teenager, uh, and it was an awful thing, but every, just about everything I owned burned up in it, including all my clothing. And you don't realize how much of our identity, especially as a kid is wrapped up in your wardrobe, right? I had to go out shopping. I went to the local Walmart and bought a couple outfits of things and I'm wearing it and I don't feel like me. I'm somebody else. You know, little changes like this, um, have, have big effects on an individual level, right? So when you mess with your senses, when you rearrange their balance, you change who you are individually. You put those individuals together and you have a society, a culture, you know, um, it change, it changes in your senses affect you individually and affect you culturally. This is, uh, very much the underpinning of, of McLuhan work where, where the medium is the message is because it's not the content that messes with your senses. The content is the delivery mechanism paradoxically for the changes introduced by the medium, you know, and it's in this sense that the content is irrelevant. You know, it, it doesn't really matter so much if we're talking about this or if we're talking about beehives or tetrahedrons or whatever else, you know, uh, the content is just what's keeping us occupied while these forces are in action and shaping us. So, uh, you know, as it says in Understanding Media, I love how Marshall, um, paraphrases so many different people in that book, but TS Eliot, he paraphrased when he said that content is the juicy piece of meat used by the burglar to distract the watchdog of the mind. And that's what he's talking about. You know, the content is what keeps us busy and, uh, unaware while this rearrangement is happening quite between beneath our notice, you know, uh, as he said, also everybody experiences far more than they understand. Amazing. I'll make a few points and then ask some questions from live chat. So sense also has a broad scope in active inference because sense is just used to cover all inbound dependencies. So that could include sensors, uh, senses changing within a lifetime differential accessibility, um, or just different ways of modeling inputs of systems. So sense is super broad on the incoming sense making side action is all outgoing dependencies, all the kinds of behaviors that emit from a system. So that's why the theory of the interface and conditioning on the interface and the boundary or the blanket that that's such a key move that allows the conditioning upon particularity. Um, and then also like given that kind of multimodal sense, technology objects come in bundles, um, the smell and the mass and the look and the sound, they do all co-occur in the product and in the material reality of media. And then even if that weren't the case, like somehow bizarrely attention would still have its own dynamics. So, so much of the brunt of the receipt of information, um, rather than falling into this payload content deliverable packet envelope, like it's kind of this naive, like, well, the meaning is right there on the pages right there in the book. And then it's like being like, well, yes, once you've zeroed out the fact that it's a letter, you can

abstract the information and talk about it maybe in a more general, um, or de materialize or however, it's, um, seen, but, but the primacy, which is so, um, glaring is our sensory perception and active perception with the eye, the blind spot, the low resolution vision in the periphery, these features that belied the generative nature of our experience period. And we know that there's frequencies that we don't pick up like radio and then radio appears. And all of a sudden that changes our sensory environment. So this is a, um, very fun exercise to see how many of these concordances, which were observed, um, and intuited and worked after in the McLuhan tradition, how many of these, because they're grounded in like qualitative prima facie aspects of experience.

Yeah.

Yeah.

Alex Mitry

for moving the field forward to 1976, but then the shelf life dropped and the older things that took longer in terms of the change to understand, they start to punch way above their weight.

And also it's cool to connect all the dots in conversation.

Yeah. A large part of the reason why Marshall McLuhan's work remains vital and important in our time is because he examines media as a category and talks about media in general and not simply different media in particular. You know, if all his work was just studying television, then, you know, obviously I wouldn't have much to say about today. But this book *Understanding Media* for example, is if you look at it, it's two parts. Part one is seven chapters and part two is 26 chapters coming again to new numbers and numerology and not accidental. You know, Marshall favored the trivium, but we have what classical education was modeled on the seven liberal arts. So that's the trivium of writing, sorry, of grammar, dialectic and rhetoric. And it's the quadrivium of astronomy, math, music, and I always forget one of them. Anyway, I consider I think about part one of *Understanding Media* as McLuhan's seven liberal arts, seven liberal arts of media, because what it is, is it is each of those chapters is a different perspective, a different way of looking at any technology, any human innovation, not just communications media. But if you look at at part two, the chapters go from speech to clothing to housing to cars to television. It's human innovation. It's not just communication. It's technology. It's anything that we do to increase, you know, the abilities we're born with, essentially. And that's what Marshall is studying. So each of those first seven chapters, and you'll get a lot from the book, if you look at it this way, each of those chapters is one perspective or method or way of looking at technologies. Part two is taking these seven principles from part one and applying them on particular technologies, and putting that in action. That's why this book is so great. And it's perennial and evergreen, because it's it's a guidebook. Not simply situated in, you know, technology up to 1964, but useful today. It's wild that, you know, I've read the book several times, I've led two groups of students through it from cover to cover, word by word, in a process that's 36 two or three hour classes. And every time I lead people through that book, it's as if the book was written today to talk about what's happening today. Because it was.

Alex Mitry 7

share any interesting anecdotes or stories about your grandfather and his work that may not be widely known um uh i mean like what imp you have to be a little more specific that's uh okay well we'll get a follow-up um from upcycle club next question the intuitive artist writes how is context contextuality recontextualization understood within the model

um yeah so that's a great question context contextuality um you know
it's tricky talking about media and looking at uh mcclellan in media um you know
it's a very good question to ask well what does he mean by media or what is a medium
um as it's tricky because uh you know like a lot of human uh a lot of english the english language
and other languages um a single word can have several meanings right uh the word medium is no
different because medium can be it can be used to talk about an instrument uh like a specific medium
like the pen or it can be used as a right it can be used as a word to talk about uh like a growing
medium a culture an environment um and it's interesting to me that uh understanding media comes
keep in mind again that understanding media is published in 1964 but the source material was
written 1958 to 1960 and rewritten and rewritten and rewritten until it was published in 64.
um as that that art comes along uh one of one of the very very important pieces in the mcclellan canon
is a work published in the at the end of 1965 or written uh it's dated november 1965 called the
relation of environment to anti-environment this is a very very important piece
um and a lot of it has to do with the senses and he says um we have we have no reason to be grateful
to those who juggle this uh sensory thresholds in the name of haphazard innovation i love this line
this is one of my favorite lines we have no reason to be grateful to those who juggle the sensory
ratios in the name of haphazard innovation he's talking about inventors and technology companies
people who create these new tools um who essentially are creating devices which juggle our sensory
thresholds um you know the the tolerances of our senses you know the individual quality of each sense
where they peak uh how much they're used the ratio among them that every new technology when it when
it you know is used essentially um affects those senses re-jiggles re-wires remodels
them affects them individually and collect collectively and creates at the at the end
you know a particular balance of the senses um the new technologies that come along
juggle these sensory thresholds in the name of haphazard innovation so like we design a technology
to be able to make phone calls as we're out and about or listen to music on the go or
whatever whatever whatever other objective or aim we have but the the effect is always
much different than the objective right the side effects always end up adding up to more than the
main effects or the intended effects the intended effects are one thing the actual effects are another
and so it's he calls it haphazard innovation because we don't actually plan for most of what the effects are
um however i think uh you know i'm drifting a little bit away from from the context question but not really
um marshall's object um sometimes expressed in this term media ecology was to take more control over
these effects because um he said you know there's absolutely no inevitability as long as there's a
willingness to comprehend the situation to pay attention the thing is uh you know the environments
the environment is a very dynamic active large complicated place um and as i said before
everybody experiences so much more than they understand there's so much i mean in your own
body there's so much happening right now that's quite beneath your level of awareness you're breathing
the blood flowing through your body oxygenization you know the hair follicles whatever you might have
left at this point growing your senses dulling or you know growing sharper all these things are happening

um quite underneath your notice um if you think about your body as an environment but think about a larger environment which only only gets more complex you know um but we don't we don't generally think about the larger environment or ecosystem when we design things we tend to have a very very narrow focus um although it was marshall's contention that we didn't need to be you know there there doesn't need to be any ignorance in these matters once we understand that there's anything that we're not paying attention to

right um so his idea of taking control of technology um had a lot to do with a kind of environmentalism and environmental activism more than you know the silly stuff that happens in congress and whatever else where they argue about censorship and people's rights and all this stuff which uh well anyway that's another another subject isn't it well just one short comment on that and then i'll ask a question from the live chat media if we say something like mainstream media it's kind of like oh yeah it's a newspaper or it's the internet or the tv but it's this kind of whatever it is whereas in the art world media or in the scientific laboratory culture media is the growth medium and so it's the medium of creation and that allies it essentially only entirely with ecological psychology and it's more of a um secondary connection or a secondary use that it's applied to what we call the media in terms of communications apparatuses by multiple names yeah um you know i mentioned uh anti-environment and that's it's not a term that you hear uh you can marshall mcclellan was essentially as he defined it an anti-environmentalist although i never heard him use it quite that way um an anti-environment is essentially any device or situation that helps you apprehend an environment okay so it's like putting dye in in the water in order to to follow the flow of of a stream or underground current right that's an anti-environment marshall categorized artists as anti-environments um because they're people

or you know the court jester who's there to point out things that people are missing as uncomfortable as they might be um and it's generally uncomfortable this is actually you know people don't don't generally think about it this way but um marshall mcclellan uh had an object you know he he had uh an intent a mission that he was undertaking and that that intention was um to wake people up to the things happening around them in the name of haphazard innovation to understand that um you know technology the content level the understanding the meaning level is just the very very tip of the iceberg in terms of what we do um when we mediate yes yet another sense of media to mediate and intermediate all right i'll read a comment and then a question from the chat so dean writes sensory attenuation so the suppressing of attention would seem to play an important role in an effects-based approach to understanding media and here's a question from chris bennett who wrote how does the move to ar vr compare to the move from printed

media to radio

um

that's a good question

uh you know this term ar augmented reality makes me laugh a little bit because

um any technology augments reality you know alters to alter our perception is to alter our reality

um you know for all intents and purposes um but the move move to say it again the move from from print

to radio and the move the current move implied from a to ar vr big if okay compared to the move from printed media to radio

yeah well you know it's interesting um

another another one of the tools from understanding media the second chapter

which confuses a lot of people is media hot and cool

hot and cool media and these are relative terms

you know think about the temperature of the water is it hot is it cold they're relative terms

right compared to one another um what's what's hot compared to one thing might be cold compared to

another thing right very relative terms but um marshall the way marshall use them for for examining

if not understanding media or technology is uh again it comes down to sense the senses and

um it's it's a bit of another equation which runs a little bit like this um that the the more information

the the quality of the information that is how rich it is in intensity uh coming at you or complete or

incomplete um has a proportionate response from you so um if you're if you're given a lot of information

like in a photograph for example a photograph is very rich visually very full of information

um a high definition um it doesn't require a lot from you to um to make sense so to speak right to get something from it

uh a cartoon in contrast is very low in definition very low in information compared to a photograph for

example in a cartoon you have uh you know usually a very simple representation of something and a narrative

sequence that there's a lot happening between frames you know that you kind of fill in it requires a lot from you in order to make something of it to complete this is what marshall's talking about when he talks about

participation um oftentimes it's not so much active participation but sensory participation like uh in

film right in in film traditional film that is what you have actually is a is a sequence of still images that

speed up enough in order to trick the eye into seeing movement um in in sequential movement uh in natural

flowing movement which actually isn't isn't there it's it's a rapid sequence of of still images um you're

involved to a very deep extent in keeping up this illusion and making sense of the thing making it work

um so one way to to look at the nature of any given technology is to analyze it in terms of its definition

and the image or information proffered um to know what kind of effect it has in return and uh it's the

demand that it makes um and what that you know means in return so uh from print to radio well you're dealing

with very different sensory spaces for one thing um you know the print print which uh involves the eye

and occupies the eye um and radio which involves uh is very much lower uh in information obviously lower

in visual information uh you it keeps your mind busy making pictures and stuff um in a different way than

the than the visual does uh ar and vr are very very rich uh you know if hot is high definition these are very

very very hot things um they don't leave much for for you to do but sit sit and stare right it's interesting the

the reactions people are having to apple vision pro um it's almost a religious experience it's so rich

uh it's interesting to me that the way that screens operate you know with the light coming through

one of our our first technologies using the light through principle were stained glass windows

as if we almost intuitively understood how deeply religious and effect and experience it has yes well the curiosity what's on the other side of the blanket what's on the other side of the veil what's on the other side of the interface like it's kind of the unknowable but that's where the mind imagines and then to return to your earlier point about like the impact of information so there's the syntax of data just in a digital setting it's like is it a 1080p video is it 4k is it 8k is 360 video so all these kind of brandings and resolution differences that's definitely part of the um experience and then there's the semantics and there might be a super high resolution photo with one object there might be a low resolution photo of many objects and then it comes up through the recipient dependent unpacking all the way on through like narrative consequences so there could be a high resolution photo and someone could flip through vacation photos very rapidly and take in a gigabyte of data and then some pixels of a stick figure could be very shocking for them and have this total influence and so that's part of the multifaceted challenge of talking about like information and communication and media understanding that it is kind of all last miles and yet the challenge and the task is to make those kinds of timeless artifacts that are of pragmatic and epistemic value in future moments yeah you know it's it's really interesting to me that um generative ai is typically used to make uh quote-unquote photo realistic images uh experiences because not just still images but now video and stuff as well

um whereas there's there seems to be a parallel um this 8-bit 16-bit uh you know gif crypto punk crypto stuff is at the complete opposite end of that that spectrum because that's very very very low definition i've yet to see anybody using mid journey or whatever else to to produce low definition experiences um they seem to be geared toward very very high definition experiences which uh i don't know what it means it's just an interesting observation to me yeah one interesting part with the writing and with the images is partially through training and so on on people's approval it generates hyper salient or hyper normative types of content relative to what it's trained upon of course this is a topic we can go into but it just always so overblown and intense like a movie poster and just but always taken to like the nth degree rather than the kind of looking like it's from the 1990s like very normal photo realism that has still more of a real flavor than the hyper normal and all of these kinds of things okay upcycle club is back with a specification okay i will try to make my question more explicit smiley face do you have a story to share about your grandfather's interest in the fisher spasky chess match and how he related it to his media theory if you could summarize that if you know about it that would be um i don't uh you know i i have very few um first person anecdotes to share about marshall uh because uh i was a baby when he died uh i was you know two years old i was born in the summer of 78 and he died in the winter of 80 so um you know i was not quite two years old but uh oh sorry i was two and a half years old um the interesting thing to me is it's really wild to see pictures of of him holding me as a as a kid um i was just starting to talk you know i was making noises and he had had a a major stroke um the previous year the fall of 1979 and he couldn't talk uh he could only just kind of babble and make noises and i was i've been told that um we had great conversations with each other that nobody outside

of us could understand whether we understood each other or simply enjoyed each other i don't know
um i i wish i could remember maybe there's some kind of regressive hypnotherapy that could
surface some things i don't know um i don't think i need to go there i think i can enjoy
the knowledge that it happened and you know that we were able to enjoy each other's presence like that
um you know when people know about that time of his life that he lived the last 18 or so months of his life
um unable to communicate uh in the manner in which he was accustomed and listen the manner to which he
was accustomed
was he had such an active mind um and his he worked it out in dialogue uh mostly orally you know speaking
to
himself to others to whoever happened to be around whether they wanted to hear it or not um to have that
suddenly cut off
a lot of people um talk about the irony you know or the tragedy that um this guy could no longer do that
and i think um certainly at first uh it would have been a shock and and horrible um you know
to only be able to make yourself understood through gestures and you know very basic things like that
uh to not be able to express the thoughts that you're having maybe not to be able to have the
thoughts that you're used to having um much less write them down or speak them uh certainly a kind of
torture at times however um i think there's a lot of relief in there too that not being able to
to provide that function not being able to to do that um frees you from having to do it um i see pictures
from that time a visit that he made to ted carpenter on long island uh playing around in in the ocean with
ted carpenter and the biggest smile on his face the biggest smiles you've never seen somebody so happy
uh there's a freedom there a great freedom and when robbed or relieved depending on how you want to
look at it of the ability and the necessity to communicate deeply if you want to get any enjoyment out of life
uh you have to find it where you can and uh i like to think that myself my sisters uh i didn't oh yeah
there was a cousin or two around at that point um i know where i find my pleasures you know i have two
young
kids uh and a wife and our relationship just being with each other is so fulfilling and
uh i think for the first time maybe in his life certainly in you know a long time he was he was able
to enjoy the simpler things communing with his family communing with his god you know i would imagine a lot
of prayer uh and in that kind of experience would happen in those circumstances um
um you know sometimes our biggest challenges are our biggest opportunities
well thank you for sharing that that was very special and you said he was robbed or relieved
essentially at this partial removal from the oral discourse community of which he wrote and spoke so much
about who and to have the crossover point on the the rising sun and the setting sun of language
uh that that uh and then even how much do those special events need to be dissected or what does
dissection do when the media ecosystem rolls forward and doesn't dissect the fermentation of the past
the first question but thank you and upcycle club says thank you as well you're welcome upcycle club
where would you like to take it or what's a question or a thought or i can read something else
from the live chat yeah go ahead what's the the live chat okay okay richard writes mcluhan called the age of

movable type is fragmented and the electronic age is global but it seems the situation is the opposite a small number of books were common to all literates but electronic media is targeted to each consumer differently

mojo writes good to view them in the light of markov blankets and how they maintain themselves through perturbations and social movements and this is something that like we've explored a lot in active inference and the social sciences is well what does a formalism do for the social and how do we approach and tackle and address the social in all of its complexities and what does going into that forest with this formalism or toolkit do is the formalism or the toolkit in account oh yeah the social group no worries just generative model and then what dust it off and walk away so how do we see the formalism as the beginning of an investigation and inquiry rather than how it's sometimes positioned in like a disciplinary or learning environment that the framework of the abstraction is the terminus of the inquiry and bend the attention back to addressing specific systems

i've never i i'm not familiar with was markov blanket yes it's a topic in active it's on a base graph when there's some variables that insulate other variables so like earlier talking about the sense as the incoming dependencies and the action as the outgoing dependencies another exactly equivalent way to say that is the external states only influence the internal states through sense and the internal states only influence the external states through action another way to say that is no telepathy no telekinesis just at a first pass but there's an interface that is insulating the cognitive states and the affective and the bodily is insulated off from just coarsely let's just say the video studio and what they're broadcasting it's moving through a medium and then there's the semantic unpacking and if something was shown but you weren't paying attention to it then it was as good as not there versus if something was seen that that wasn't there in the mind of the broadcaster that's kind of a non sequitur because that's what is happening yeah interesting um of course again there's that quote that uh you know we experience far much more than we understand now you don't you don't have to understand anything about effects to register and be affected by things you know um others i wondered when barry would show up this cat honestly i was giving a guest lecture last night for an nyu class and this cat is literally sitting back here going meow meow meow meow the whole time i'm like trying to gather my thoughts and this cat is like heckling me uh well played barry damn um

yeah again you know environments and in anti-environments but uh there's this uh funny exchange it's it's on the internet of course on youtube um buck mr fuller marshall mccluhan and wh oddin on a panel together uh debating television discussing debating television and uh one of my favorite lines from that is you know odd and is uh you know a playwright guy he's very anti-television and it's like i'm a television i wouldn't i wouldn't dream of of having a television and marshall says well you merely suffer the consequences without enjoying any of the benefits and a point there is that you don't need to have a television you don't need to watch television to be affected by the television as a medium as you know something which is running our society same with smartphones you might not have a smartphone but you live in a society that runs on the smartphone so um yeah it's interesting what marshall is saying here because he's almost saying well you know you might as

well have it and get some benefits some use some enjoyment out of the thing if you're gonna be affected by it anyway right but he's he's being kind of tongue-in-cheek about that uh but still the point the point remains and you know it's the nature of of an environment is that um there's uh there's little escape we we have only the crudest uh ways of maintaining an environment a technological environment um one way is uh to do what some amish or hutterite uh communities do which is they impose technology hard technological limits you know that's like they basically freeze technology at the uh level to which because it's interesting they they understand um even if it's unconsciously that to introduce these different technologies would destroy their culture they're not wrong they're they're quite right about it um and the only the only thing we can do at this point is to uh protect our environment from it right walling off a community it's you know the crudest it's crude but effective you know a much more sophisticated way to do it would be well what is it about this technology

that would interrupt what we value from our community and then to design the technology accordingly like but that requires a really really deep understanding of uh the instrument and and again it really comes down to sensory things because you know generally cultures protectionist cultures like this are trying to protect um specific parts of their culture and uh that's a very very difficult um things to do to do in the face of change isn't it barry yeah um but it is you know it may be it may be crude but effective um it's one thing you know i live i've got two kids as i mentioned uh they're six and eight years old and uh well they're just about to turn sorry eight and ten years old which is crazy but um uh or sorry seven and nine how old are my kids again geez time what is time but uh uh it's it's it's very it's very difficult to be a parent uh today especially when you understand as i do how important technology is in shaping who your kids are becoming as people uh it's wild i see and again parenting i think is the toughest gig do you have any kids daniel not yet okay parenting is the toughest gig and i have so much respect from other parents because it's difficult um and you know i don't want to judge anybody and tell people that they're doing it right or wrong it's the context situations are different but you know i see uh i also know too much you know i understand uh what happens cognitively and sensorily when you're exposed to different technologies i know that the society the person brought up uh around literature in the environment of literature versus the person brought up in an environment absence of literature and rich in technology like screens televisions smartphones etc um are tend to produce very different results uh your brain your senses are wired in particular pathways um that set you up for life um which isn't to say they don't change because they do um you know our senses our brains these things are plastic they're elastic to a certain extent but they're set up in in the first couple of years of life so uh you know marshall at one point is it an understanding media wonders out loud about uh people developing the habits of literacy after being raised on television and wondering if this isn't uh not a great way to go around it if the process should be perhaps reversed um the difficulty is the barrier to entry you know so i see i see a kid in a baby carriage right is isn't old enough to walk on their own without falling over and the parent hands them a smartphone or an i a tablet right an ipad whatever

and the kid pokes at it and is off to the races can do a lot of things versus drop drop this into a kid's lap right in the baby carriage and what's it going to do it's going to eat it that's about all it can do is chew on it it takes it takes years and years and years in order to open this and to to make this these pages these letters whatever do anything for you you know not even any any pictures unless the kid's a fan of you know concrete poetry or something at the age of one or two it's not going to get very far it's um so you know these things versus each other it's obvious which one is going to win right this is um um and this sets up the kid uh in a certain way versus versus this um but i get it parenting is a tough gig and uh god i just want some peace and quiet sometimes myself you know and it's easy to give a kid a device and they keep themselves happy for hours and hours and hours in fact um the average american citizen between the ages of eight and 18 now consumes eight and a half hours of non of screen time every day for non-educational purposes is the statistic so this doesn't count um the screen time for school or for educational purposes and that right there tells you so much about the lack of understanding on the part of government agencies because they make a distinction between educational and non-educational as if it's a distinction that makes a difference when it comes down to the sensory neurological psychological psychological sensory cultural identity effects of technologies these things do not occur on the level of opinions concepts or content at all uh and every time we get a new statistic that says something like that it shows how little our understanding has come and how far we have to go if we're ever going to make any headway and take any control over our technological lives and the direction of culture which is an easy thing to say from this side of the screen thank you that's very powerful and it just makes me think about how the the payload content the meaning is inside of the envelope perspective leads to these ideological distinctions and lines and shifting in the sand and all this but that's kind of like an adult literary discussion like well here's a quote where this word was used this way but while that debate was happening or discussion or whatever um the the baseball diamond and the sports field have been transformed with screens such that basically no matter where in a downtown area or like even in restaurants or on train even things that when i was younger were not seen so where's the discussion around that and part of it is hindered by just like you described like that kind of um affordance at hand and the kind of low activation energy um so the concept that it's a personal choice however everything can kind of be understood in terms of personal choice and constraint too um and just how that whole semantics discussion like is on a separate concept of media than what is happening moment to moment for like 8.5 or 18.5 hours per day with complete permanent consequences on everything yeah it's wild um you know i understand as i do these things um i try to spend as little time on the screen as i can uh but it's still a lot of time um whenever i i'm able to uh i read something off off the page rather than the screen i've got you know 6 000 books here for example um and my ideal is to try and balance right like spend as much time reading uh as i do on screens and it's impossible it's a daily battle that i'm losing big time uh uh you know emails and correspondences and things like this and um you know i'd much rather have this conversation in person uh but this is the reality of things and you know what this this reality of things also means i can do a lot that i wouldn't otherwise be able to do

because i'm talking to you here from a 19th century barn in rural southern ontario
um from here because of my internet access i'm able to lead courses on understanding media
that have 20 30 students from around the world joining me for a couple hours a week for 36 weeks
um simply because of of this fact this circumstance this medium this environment of services and
disservices and for all the disservices it it makes things possible that would otherwise not be because
if i were to hold this class here i don't think i'd get a student you know i don't think i'd get a single
person come uh certainly not enough to make it make sense and this is why i think about it um
i think about it like like new york city new york city is my ideal because you know uh anything anything
is possible there with eight million people uh at your doorstep essentially
you can open up a small shop that you know caters to buckminster fuller dome building kits or something
and probably make a living you know out of eight million people your community a community can coalesce
it can assemble can find each other can exist and support uh the internet brings eight billion people
potentially to my barn you know it means i can connect um in the same way that that new york city can
and you know try to make a modest living out of what i do so as much as uh you know obviously that's
that's the thing that make tech makes technology work um is the affordance is the things that makes
possible and we just have to deal with the fallout and with the things that it makes impossible uh the
things that it you know one environment sustains certain things and and not others um i talk we talk a
big game about the senses and media ecology and being more intentional about design but it is essentially
theoretical um because i'm not building hardware or software or anything else although i am talking to
people who are um and that's who i'm trying to reach people who are designing the technologies that
are going to be creating the environments of tomorrow um this i think our greatest area of opportunity
um and it's actually why i remain very hopeful you know because uh
again mixed blessings but it's never been easier uh the barriers keep dropping away
you know the technological change happens so quickly now because such powerful tools are at our fingertips
our literal fingertips um you know even 30 years ago you didn't have the access to supercomputers
uh shared time and stuff um relatively affordable things access to information computing power building
things
uh now is easier for younger people to do this is where i think there's hope because
um it's easier for younger people to follow their dreams and their ideals
younger people uh want to do you know i think everybody a lot of people want to do the right thing
but it's easier for younger people to actually do the right thing because they have left to lose less to lose
you know here i am approaching middle age or whatever i have kids i've got a mortgage you know bills to pay
i gotta do what i gotta do but you know a teenager people in their young 20s and startups developing
technologies they don't have a house they don't have kids they have fewer responsibilities fewer fears
they can follow those their hearts and their dreams and now with the access to tools and services and
computing power and things um and financing particularly they don't have to take they don't have to make
hard
decisions that other people used to have to do you know um they don't have to take money from one place

uh there's another place uh there's another place to take money from funding you know and this gives me hope

um because as i said i think they're more more likely because they're in a better position

maybe to do uh to make harder choices that are maybe easier for them sorry that's a very fuzzy and convoluted way of trying to express what i'm trying to express but i hope it comes through

thank you well as we sort of land the plane where and how are you going to continue your work and also

i would love to hear a little bit about the consequences or implications for education

and for online for example technical online education and all these different things like that

sure yeah um i mean i'm i'm gonna keep on keeping on pretty much uh i've got you know what i'm trying

to do here is preserve the work and the way of work that my grandfather started back in the 40s and 50s

that my my father jumped in and kept going uh from the 60s through the 80s and 90s and early thousands

and i've been left with a lot of stuff uh in physical form and a lot of begun projects and half finished things

um and my role which i take on with absolute delight is to preserve that and make it a

available uh for today and tomorrow um how i do that i'm still figuring out uh you know i'm independent

you know the mccluan institute is essentially me it's not uh it's not a registered business or anything

else i'm not affiliated with any business or other institution i don't get any government or private

funding really um i've got a patreon page go ahead and join that if you want i've got a sub stack which

you can subscribe to the mccluan newsletter um i sell stuff through my bookshop and whatnot and basically

the money that i make teaching giving speeches consulting uh you know i pour back into uh here

um ideally um you know i would spend less time doing the exterior stuff and more time in here doing

the work that i think is more valuable and important but um you know means to an end and it is what it is

right now um the future uh you know i don't think people for a long time i don't think people have gone to

school to really get an education uh to learn important things um going to school has more been about

you know because that's why universities were begun is centralized knowledge to make it available for

people but um as many people have pointed out there's more information available outside the university

than in it at this point and that's been true for a century or more um so going to school is more about

socialization networking status credentials that kind of thing um when people want to learn things

uh that they're passionate about they they go generally i'm speaking very broadly um they have many other

different ways to do it i've been very fortunate to be able to offer classes and courses and stuff for

like i said people from around the world students to retired professors to professionals across industries

and i think that is uh increasingly the future is this uh self-directed learning um it's interesting that

uh it's happening uh it's facilitated more and more from businesses you know people are encouraged to

continue learning to build their skill set to follow their interests to develop and grow because change happens so fast

you want people that are not uh specialists and kind of dead people right we all need to keep uh growing and expanding

because this environment and the things within it keep growing and expanding uh to stand still is to you know to die essentially so um i'm gonna i'm gonna keep on doing that uh following my own nose and interests you

know

uh doing my best to translate and interpret and make available bridging generations uh as i can and i'm really glad to have uh

all you along with me and together for this ride

amazing i resonate with a lot of that so thank you for the work and to our colleague who introduced us us and to the live chat for many great topics and questions and let's stay in touch and maybe

69.2 and then you know dare i say 69.3 when the time is right

awesome hey good to talk to you take care everybody thank you andrew peace

so

so

Thank you.